

How?

Adverbs that describe how actions are performed are known as adverbs of manner. They are formed from adjectives and modify verbs. These adverbs can be placed before or after the verb, or at the beginning or end of a clause. Like adjectives, most adverbs of manner and frequency can be graded by adverbs of degree, such as *very*, *quite*, or *almost*. These are always placed directly before the adjective or adverb they describe.

This adverb of degree is modifying the adverb of manner *quietly*—it indicates how quietly they left.

We left *very* quietly

This adverb of manner is at the end of a clause, and is modifying the verb *left*—it is describing how they left.

an *extremely* large dog

This adverb of degree is modifying the adjective *large*—it is explaining how large the dog was.



- Some **adverbs of degree**, such as *just*, *only*, *almost*, and *even*, must be placed immediately in front of the word they are modifying: for example, “I have **just** arrived.”

Sentence adverbs

Sentence adverbs are unusual because they do not just modify a verb—they modify the whole sentence or clause containing that verb. They usually express the likelihood or desirability of something happening, and include words like *unfortunately*, *probably*, and *certainly*. They can also be used to influence the reader.

This adverb is modifying a whole clause, meaning “it is unfortunate that an extremely large dog saw us.”

***unfortunately* an extremely large dog saw us**

**very quietly, but unfortunately
We’ll run more quickly next time.**

Comparing adverbs

Like adjectives, adverbs of manner can be compared. To form the comparative, *more* is usually added before the adverb. In the same way, *most* is added before the adverb to form the superlative.

**more quickly
most quickly**



- Then*** is an **adverb of time**, and should **not** be used as a **conjunction**. When joining two clauses together, use a conjunction such as *and* before *then*.
- Don’t overuse adverbs.** In the phrase “*absolutely* fabulous,” the adverb ***absolutely*** adds nothing to the adjective ***fabulous***, which already implies high levels of enthusiasm for something.

The three **most common adverbs** in English are ***not***, ***very***, and ***too***.

GLOSSARY

Adverbial phrase A group of words such as “in July of last year” that perform the same role as an adverb and answer questions such as: How? When? Where? How often?